

1 Sunlight

Rays of light from the Sun shine toward the falling raindrops.

When you see a rainbow, the Sun will always be behind you and the rain will be in front of you.

We see the Sun's rays as pure white light.

What is a rainbow?

If the Sun shines in the sky when it is raining, sunlight bounces off the raindrops and splits into different colors that you see as a rainbow. The colors you can usually see in a rainbow are red, orange, yellow, green, blue, indigo, and violet.

Quick quiz



When might you see a rainbow?



What colors are in a rainbow?



When might a red rainbow appear?

A range of rainbows

When sunlight is reflected twice in the same raindrop you may see a double rainbow—a second rainbow that sits outside the main rainbow with its colors in the opposite order. There are also lunar rainbows (when moonlight passes through raindrops) and red rainbows (which happen at dawn or dusk), but these are rare.



Double rainbow